

obvious form was stage magic—professional performances of ingenious tricks, conjuring, and seemingly supernatural illusions that drew packed audiences. Another craze was spiritualism—speaking with the dead. Séances became the fashion, in the parlor as well as on the stage. Celebrity mediums proliferated, as did tales of their ability to conjure ghosts and ectoplasm (the supernatural substance that was supposed to enable spirits to manifest themselves) out of thin air. A similar type of spirit belief was spiritism. In its Western form, developed by Allan Kardec, followers believed in reincarnation.

Spiritist thinking also flourished in Latin America and the Caribbean, in forms such as Espiritismo, which blended indigenous and imported beliefs.

Some eminent scientists gave credence to spiritualism, though there were also investigations into its fraudulence. Just as in the Renaissance when people variously viewed alchemists as magicians, experimenters, or charlatans, so many in this period thought that if scientists could produce something as extraordinary as electricity, it was possible that mediums could conjure up ectoplasmic ghosts and allow communication with their lost loved ones.

“The traditions of Esoteric Philosophy must be the right ones
... they are the most logical, and reconcile every difficulty.”

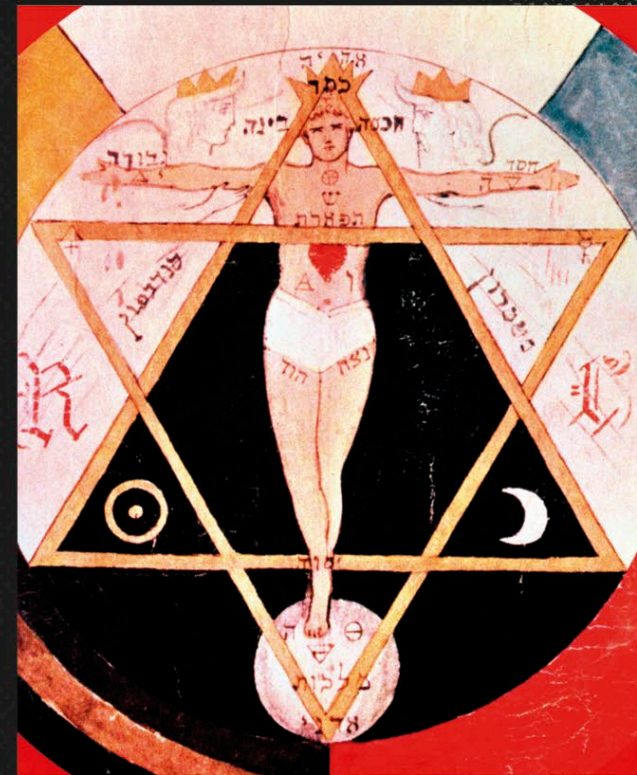
HELENA BLAVATSKY, *THE SECRET DOCTRINE*, 1888



Gothic horror see p.222



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Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn see p.243